The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

29th January 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Hinge (निर्भर करना)

Meaning: To depend entirely on or be contingent upon.
Synonyms: Depend, rest, pivot
Antonyms: Disregard, detach, separate
Example: The success of the project hinges on securing adequate funding.

2. Scrutiny (जाँच-पड़ताल)

Meaning: Close and detailed examination or observation.
Synonyms: Inspection, analysis, review
Antonyms: Neglect, ignorance, overlook
Example: The financial records were subject to intense scrutiny during the audit.

VOCABULARY

3. Debilitating (कमजोर करने वाला)

Meaning: Making someone very weak or infirm.
Synonyms: Crippling, weakening, exhausting
Antonyms: Strengthening, invigorating, energizing
Example: The disease had a debilitating effect on his ability to perform daily tasks.

4. Bustling (व्यस्त और चहल-पहल भरा)

Meaning: Full of energetic and noisy activity.
Synonyms: Lively, busy, vibrant
Antonyms: Quiet, idle, calm
Example: The marketplace was bustling with shoppers and vendors.

VOCABULARY

5. Scaffolding (ढांचा)

Meaning: A temporary structure used to support work during construction or repair.
Synonyms: Framework, structure, support
Example: The crumbling scaffolding highlighted the fragility of the city's infrastructure.

6. Diminution (घटाव)

Meaning: A reduction in the size, extent, or importance of something.
Synonyms: Decrease, reduction, decline, lessening
Antonyms: Increase, expansion, enlargement, augmentation
Example: The diminution of the company's profits worried the investors.

VOCABULARY

7. Elusive (दुर्गम / समझने में कठिन)

Meaning: Difficult to find, achieve, or recall; hard to grasp or define.
Synonyms: Evasive, intangible, ambiguous, fleeting
Antonyms: Accessible, clear, definite, obvious
Example: The concept of time remains elusive to even the most brilliant scientists.

8. Trifle (तुच्छ वस्तु / मामूली बात)

Meaning: A thing of little value or importance.
Synonyms: Triviality, unimportance, insignificance
Antonyms: Significance, importance, necessity
Example: Don’t waste your time arguing over such trifles; focus on the bigger picture.

VOCABULARY

9. Muzzling (रोकना)

Meaning: Preventing someone from expressing their opinions freely.
Synonyms: Suppressing, silencing, stifling, restraining
Antonyms: Liberating, encouraging, freeing, allowing
Example: The government was accused of muzzling the media to control public opinion.

10. Reiterated (दोहराया)

Meaning: Say something again or a number of times, typically for emphasis or clarity.
Synonyms: Repeated, restated, emphasized, reaffirmed
Antonyms: Retracted, revoked, rescinded
Example: The CEO reiterated the company's commitment to sustainability.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Cut down
Meaning: To reduce something in size, quantity, or use.

2. Come along
Meaning: To arrive or appear; to make progress or improve.

3. Lie down
Meaning: To recline or rest in a horizontal position.

4. Go off
Meaning: To explode or make a sudden noise (e.g., an alarm); to leave a place; to spoil (e.g., food).

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. Every nook and corner

Meaning - every part or aspect of something

2. Cast in the same mold

Meaning - to be very similar in character to someone else

3. To err is human

Meaning - it's normal for people to make mistakes

VOCABULARY

4. To make mountain of the mole hill

Meaning - to cause something unimportant to seem important

5. Add fuel to fire

Meaning - to make an argument or bad situation worse

Article for Reading

A question of hygiene: on the Guillain-Barré Syndrome outbreak in Pune

At the heart of the current Guillain-Barré Syndrome (GBS) outbreak in Pune, where over 100 cases of suspected GBS have been recorded, is a bacterial infection. A health investigation has revealed Campylobacter jejuni, a bacteria found in contaminated food and water, to be behind the first cluster of cases. In almost all the patients, recent case history has shown episodes of gastroenteritis, vomiting, diarrhoea and nausea before the onset of the characteristic peripheral numbing of GBS, leading to paralysis. One case of death due to suspected GBS has also been recorded — of a patient who had visited Pune. This outbreak reveals the fragility of the scaffolding that urban systems in India are built on, with pathogens managing to breach all safety nets that humans have built for themselves, to emerge through and cause havoc.

Any slip up in maintenance or in surveillance, clearly leads to discomfort, ill health and debility for a large number of people. GBS is a rare, autoimmune neurological disorder, in which a person's immune system launches an attack on the peripheral nervous system, leading to tingling, weakening of muscles, numbing and paralysis in the arms and legs, not unlike in the acute flaccid paralysis of polio. It can be caused by viral or bacterial pre-infections, as per the World Health Organization (WHO). Globally, it is estimated that GBS has an incidence of 1-2 per 1,00,000 population, and is more predominant among adult males. While India-specific large epidemiological studies on GBS are lacking, as testing for GBS in a resource-poor setting is difficult, according to a WHO report (1993), it was estimated that 138 cases of GBS were seen annually in seven major teaching hospitals, with approximately 75% of cases occurring in adults.

While studies across the world have shown numbers to rise in seasons of weather change, it is possible that this is India's largest outbreak in recorded history. Patients are treated with plasma exchange or intravenous immunoglobulin therapy, and most recover. However, these treatments are most effective if started within two weeks of the first symptoms, making early detection and initiation of treatment absolutely crucial. Rapid response teams in Pune are in place, collecting water samples and mounting surveillance on the community, and a central team has also been rushed to affected areas. It is key to ensure that all measures are in place to pick up patients, and initiate treatment as soon as possible. It is the duty of the local and State governance to provide clean drinking water to all residents and ensure that adequate social messaging is provided periodically on avoiding contaminated, unhygienic food.

Summary

Pune is currently experiencing a Guillain-Barré Syndrome (GBS) outbreak linked to Campylobacter jejuni, a bacteria commonly found in contaminated food and water. Over 100 suspected GBS cases, most preceded by gastroenteritis symptoms such as vomiting, diarrhea, and nausea, have been reported. GBS is an autoimmune disorder that attacks the peripheral nervous system, causing tingling, muscle weakness, numbness, and even paralysis. While it is a rare condition with a global incidence of 1-2 cases per 100,000 population, this outbreak may be India's largest recorded instance of GBS. Early treatment with plasma exchange or intravenous immunoglobulin therapy is crucial, with the best outcomes achieved when treatment starts within two weeks of symptom onset. Authorities in Pune, supported by central teams, are actively collecting water samples, conducting surveillance, and promoting hygiene awareness to control the outbreak. The crisis highlights the vulnerabilities in urban systems, emphasizing the need for clean drinking water, stringent maintenance of public health infrastructure, and consistent public education to prevent similar outbreaks in the future.

Tone:

The tone is urgent and cautionary, highlighting the seriousness of the outbreak while emphasizing the importance of preventive measures and swift medical intervention.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
What measures are being taken to control the GBS outbreak in Pune?

a) Nationwide awareness campaigns on neurological disorders.
b) Large-scale distribution of antibiotics to the affected population.
c) Collection of water samples, community surveillance, and rapid response teams.
d) Vaccination drives against Campylobacter jejuni.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
Why does the passage describe the GBS outbreak as a sign of the fragility of urban systems in India?

a) It reflects the failure of rapid response teams to contain the spread of diseases.
b) It demonstrates how pathogens can breach safety nets due to lapses in maintenance or surveillance.
c) It shows the inadequacy of healthcare facilities to handle neurological disorders.
d) It highlights the absence of public awareness campaigns on food and water safety.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

The U.S.’s immigration blocks as a self-defeating path

What do we see in the bustling corridors of Silicon Valley, the research labs of Boston, and the biotech hubs of San Diego? Skilled immigrants do not just fill jobs; they create them. They launch startups, file patents and drive innovation, expanding the very foundation of American employment. However, to understand this, we need to challenge our most basic assumptions about how labour markets work in knowledge economies. The debate over H-1B visas in the United States seems to hinge on a seemingly very intuitive argument: that restricting skilled immigration will translate into more jobs for native workers. On the contrary, extensive research has shown that this approach is flawed and, in fact, counterproductive to innovation and job creation. A study by Britta Glennon found that in response to increasing H-1B visa restrictions, American companies do not typically hire more U.S. workers. Instead, they just accelerate foreign hiring.

This might seem like an unforeseen consequence, but faced with visa restrictions, it is not entirely unthinkable that they will turn to countries with large pools of skilled workers (India and China). The numbers are very significant. A decrease of 1% in initial employment from the H-1B supply could have an impact in terms of the foreign affiliate growth rate of between 10 and 20%. And it is not just replacement hires. Entire teams and operations could move overseas. For every 10 H-1B positions denied, U.S. multinational firms hire an average of eight foreign workers abroad. Other research shows that each H-1B visa holder creates 1.83 additional jobs for native-born American workers over the next seven years. Immigrant-founded companies in the U.S. have, historically, attracted significant investment, creating jobs at higher rates than native-founded firms. Research by the National Foundation for American Policy shows that more than half of America's billion-dollar startups have been started by immigrants. The argument that H-1B workers suppress wages also does not hold up to scrutiny.

Research by Giovanni Peri and colleagues has shown that native wages actually rise when foreign science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM) workers are hired, by increasing productivity and innovation, particularly in technical fields. Aggregating at the national level, foreign STEM workers flowing in may account for 30% to 50% of the aggregate productivity growth and 4% to 8% of the skill-biased productivity growth. Another report by the American Immigration Council challenges the widespread idea that H-1B workers earn lower wages than their U.S. counterparts, and, therefore, negatively affect wage growth. For instance, it shows that the median wage for H-1B workers was more than double that for the general U.S. workforce in 2021. And between 2003 and 2021, it rose by 52%, while wages for all U.S. workers grew by 39%. Recent studies have shown that knowledge spillovers and productivity gains from high-skilled immigration actually increase native wages. When companies do not face hurdles in hiring the talent they need, they expand operations domestically, which in turn, creates more opportunities for everyone.

Question 3:
What does the passage imply about the role of immigrant-founded companies in the U.S. economy?

a) They suppress innovation by taking resources away from native entrepreneurs.
b) They create jobs at a lower rate than native-founded firms.
c) They attract significant investment and create jobs at higher rates than native-founded firms.
d) They rely heavily on government subsidies to remain competitive.
e) None of the above

Question 4:
What does the passage suggest about the wage trends for H-1B workers compared to the general U.S. workforce?

a) H-1B workers earn significantly lower wages than the general workforce.
b) H-1B wages have risen at a slower rate compared to U.S. workers.
c) H-1B wages are stagnant due to visa restrictions.
d) H-1B wages are more than double the median wage of the general workforce.
e) None of the above

Question 5:
What impact does high-skilled immigration have on native wages, according to the passage?

a) It suppresses native wages by creating competition.
b) It increases native wages through productivity and innovation.
c) It has no measurable impact on native wages.
d) It reduces wage growth in STEM fields specifically.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question:

Original Text:

Technology has revolutionized agriculture, transforming traditional farming practices into a more efficient, productive, and sustainable system. Modern agricultural technologies encompass a wide range of tools and methods, including precision farming, automation, biotechnology, and data analytics, which address the challenges of feeding a growing global population while conserving resources and reducing environmental impacts. One of the most significant advancements is precision farming, which uses GPS, drones, and sensors to monitor crop health, soil conditions, and weather patterns. These tools enable farmers to apply water, fertilizers, and pesticides precisely where needed, reducing waste and costs while improving yields.

Similarly, automation and robotics, such as autonomous tractors and harvesters, enhance efficiency by minimizing labor requirements and speeding up farming operations. Biotechnology, including genetically modified organisms (GMOs), has further improved agriculture by developing crops resistant to pests, diseases, and extreme weather conditions. These advancements reduce crop losses and ensure food security. Additionally, data analytics and artificial intelligence (AI) empower farmers to make informed decisions by analyzing vast amounts of data related to market trends, weather forecasts, and farm performance. However, the adoption of technology in agriculture comes with challenges, including high costs, lack of access to technology in rural areas, and the need for technical training. Governments and organizations must address these barriers through subsidies, infrastructure development, and education programs. The integration of technology in agriculture is essential for meeting global food demands, increasing sustainability, and ensuring the well-being of farmers and consumers alike.

Precis:

Technology has transformed agriculture into a more efficient and sustainable system through tools like precision farming, automation, biotechnology, and AI. These innovations improve crop yields, reduce waste, and address food security challenges by enabling targeted resource use and resilient crop development.

Despite challenges like high costs and limited rural access, government support and education can facilitate adoption. The use of technology in agriculture is vital for meeting global food demands while conserving resources and enhancing farmers' livelihoods.

- **Write an email to a potential business partner, proposing a collaboration for a mutual benefit. Highlight your company’s strengths and how the collaboration could be successful.**

To: ……@gmail.com

Subject: Proposal for Strategic Collaboration

Dear [Recipient's Name],

I hope this email finds you well. My name is [Your Name], and I am [Your Position] at [Your Company Name]. I am reaching out to explore a potential collaboration between our companies that I believe could be mutually beneficial and impactful.
At [Your Company Name], we specialize in [briefly mention your company's area of expertise or key offerings]. Over the years, we have built a strong reputation for [highlight key strengths such as innovation, customer satisfaction, market leadership, etc.]. Some of our notable achievements include [mention specific achievements or milestones]. I have been following [Recipient's Company Name] and am impressed by your work in [specific area or industry]. Your commitment to [mention a unique aspect of their business, e.g., quality, sustainability, innovation] aligns closely with our values and mission.

I believe that a collaboration between our companies could leverage our respective strengths to [state the purpose or benefit of the collaboration, e.g., reach new markets, develop innovative products, enhance customer experiences]. By combining [specific strengths of both companies], we could create a partnership that drives significant growth and success for both parties. I would love the opportunity to discuss this idea further and explore how we can work together to achieve our shared goals. Please let me know a convenient time for a meeting or call.

Thank you for considering this proposal. I look forward to the possibility of working together and am confident that this partnership could deliver outstanding results.

Best regards,
[Your Full Name]
[Your Position]

Match the column

1. Every nook and corner
2. Cast in the same mold
3. To err is human
4. To make mountain of the mole hill
5. Add fuel to fire

A. to be very similar in character to someone else
B. to cause something unimportant to seem important
C. to make an argument or bad situation worse
D. it's normal for people to make mistakes
E. every part or aspect of something

Answer:

1-e

2-a

3-d

4-b

5-c

Vocabulary

1. Hinge:
2. Scrutiny:
3. Debilitating:
4. Bustling:
5. Scaffolding:
6. Diminution:
7. Elusive:
8. Trifle:
9. Muzzling:
10. Reiterated:

RC ANS

1.

Ans: c

Explanation:

The passage describes the deployment of rapid response teams, collection of water samples, and community surveillance as key measures to control the outbreak.

Incorrect Options:

a) There is no mention of nationwide awareness campaigns in the passage.
b) Antibiotics are not mentioned as a treatment for GBS or as a measure against the outbreak.
d) Vaccination for Campylobacter jejuni is not referenced.

2.

Ans: b

Explanation:

Refer to the lines: “This outbreak reveals the fragility of the scaffolding that urban systems in India are built on, with pathogens managing to breach all safety nets that humans have built for themselves, ……”

The passage emphasizes that the outbreak exposes weaknesses in urban systems, where any slip-up in maintenance or surveillance allows pathogens to cause widespread harm.

Incorrect Options:

a) The rapid response teams are actively addressing the situation.
c) Healthcare inadequacy is not the central issue here.
d) While awareness is important, the passage highlights systemic lapses instead.

3.
Ans: c
Explanation:
Reference: "Immigrant-founded companies in the U.S. have, historically, attracted significant investment, creating jobs at higher rates than native-founded firms."

The passage mentions that immigrant-founded companies create jobs at higher rates than native-founded firms and have historically attracted significant investment. Over half of America's billion-dollar startups were started by immigrants.

Incorrect Options:

a) Incorrect because the passage highlights their role in fostering innovation, not suppressing it.
b) Incorrect as the passage explicitly states they create jobs at higher rates.
d) Incorrect since the passage does not mention government subsidies as a factor.

4.
Ans: d
Explanation:
Reference: "The median wage for H-1B workers was more than double that for the general U.S. workforce in 2021. And between 2003 and 2021, it rose by 52%, while wages for all U.S. workers grew by 39%."

The passage mentions that the median wage for H-1B workers in 2021 was more than double that of the general U.S. workforce. H-1B wages have also grown faster than wages for all U.S. workers.

Incorrect Options:

a) Incorrect as the passage explicitly refutes the claim that H-1B workers earn lower wages.
b) Incorrect because H-1B wages have risen faster than wages for the general workforce.
c) Incorrect since wage growth is highlighted, not stagnation.

5.
Ans: b
Explanation:
Reference: "Research by Giovanni Peri and colleagues has shown that native wages actually rise when foreign STEM workers are hired, by increasing productivity and innovation."

The passage explains that high-skilled immigration contributes to productivity gains and knowledge spillovers, which increase native wages, particularly in technical fields. Research by Giovanni Peri is mentioned to support this claim.

Incorrect Options:

a) Incorrect because the passage explicitly refutes the idea that immigration suppresses wages.
c) Incorrect as the passage highlights a positive impact on native wages.
d) Incorrect since the passage states that wages in STEM fields rise due to the productivity gains brought by skilled immigrants.

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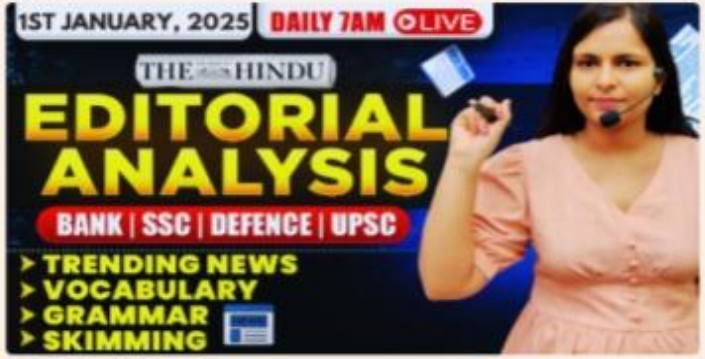

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Perfection Class: Debunking English Grammar Myths I Perfection I

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